

Held Together

A four-step nervous system practice for couples who keep trying harder and still don't feel met



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You can love someone completely and still feel like you are negotiating for scraps in your own home. Both of you exhausted. Both of you privately keeping score. Both of you asking, in a hundred small ways, to finally be enough for each other, and neither of you quite landing.

This is not because either of you is doing it wrong. It is because you have both been aiming at the same broken target: getting your own needs met. The moment two people build something bigger than either of their needs alone, most of that hunger quiets down on its own.

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This practice borrows its spine from Stan Tatkin, PsyD, a couples therapist who spent years studying what actually makes couples feel secure together, not just compatible. What he found looked backwards at first. Partners who focus on making the other person feel safe end up more met themselves than partners who focus on fixing their own needs directly. He named the container two committed people build for each other the Couple Bubble, the idea at the center of his book *Wired for Love*. What follows is my own working version of that idea, the one I actually use and teach.

Two things before you start. This only works if both of you are genuinely in, a real willingness that goes beyond just keeping the peace.

And this is not the practice for a relationship where there is active violence, coercion, or ongoing abuse. If that is where you are, please reach out to a therapist or a domestic violence support service first. This tool assumes two people who are already safe with each other and simply are not yet meeting each other well.

◆ STEP ONE

01

Name What You Actually Need

Most people can tell you exactly what is missing in their relationship the moment they are angry about it, and could not tell you an hour earlier if you asked them calmly. Need only becomes visible at the edges, when it is starving, not while it still has room to breathe. This step reverses that order. You name your needs while nothing is on fire, so later you are working from clarity instead of reaction.

Rate 1 to 10 how much you need to feel each of these, right now, in this relationship:

— Love	_____	— Safety	_____
— Security	_____	— Respect	_____
— Acceptance	_____	— Desire	_____
— Care	_____	— Connection	_____
— Excitement	_____	— Freedom	_____
— <i>Anything true for you that isn't on this list: add it.</i>		_____	

Do this alone first. Skip what you think your partner wants to hear, skip what a good partner is supposed to need, and get honest about what's actually true for you.

DO THIS

Tonight, separately, take five quiet minutes with a pen. Rate all ten. Add your own if the list is missing something true. Fold the paper. Do not compare notes yet.

◆ STEP TWO

02

Follow Your Top Three

A number on its own does not change anything. What changes things is what is underneath the number: the specific texture of when a need is met, and when it collapses. This is where "I need more respect" stops being a complaint and becomes information you can actually work with.

Take each of your top three highest-rated needs. If you share a top need, explore that one together. If your top needs differ, take turns, one thread per person. For each need, ask each other out loud:

- What would it actually feel like to have this fully?
- When do you feel the most of it? The least?
- What does your partner do that grows it? What shrinks it?
- What do you do, yourself, that grows or shrinks this feeling in you, independent of your partner?

Nobody gets to skip that last question. Half of every need you have is regulated by you, before your partner ever enters the room.

DO THIS

This week, block 45 minutes, phones in another room. Work through both of your top three lists using the four questions above. If time runs out, finish one person's list properly rather than rushing both.

◆ **STEP THREE**

03

Make the Guarantee

A vague promise does not calm a nervous system. "I'll try to be more present" gives the body nothing to track, so it keeps scanning for proof that nothing has actually changed. A guarantee is different. It is specific enough to notice when it's kept, and specific enough to notice when it slips. That is what actually builds felt safety: not the sentiment behind a promise, the repetition of it.

From what you learned in step two, write one or two guarantees. Real commitments, not directions handed to your partner:

- "I will support you to feel safe whenever I can."
- "I will make loving you more important than being right."

Both of you have to actually mean it. If one person is proposing and the other is just agreeing to keep things smooth, it will not hold. Write your guarantee down somewhere you will both see it again.

DO THIS

Sit down together and write one to two guarantees you would both actually sign your name to. Read them out loud to each other before you consider it done.

Return and Revise

Nobody's felt safety is a one-time install. Most couples write a good agreement and then never speak of it again, so it quietly expires and everyone assumes it failed. It did not fail. It just needed maintenance nobody scheduled. A guarantee that stops working partway through is not proof this doesn't work. It is information about what to try next.

Come back to your guarantees on purpose. Ask honestly: did this land? Did I feel more of what I needed? If yes, move to the next need on each of your lists. If not, don't abandon the tool. Rework the guarantee itself until it actually fits.

DO THIS

Put a date on the calendar, two weeks from today, fifteen minutes, labeled with both your names. Ask: did this work, do we keep going, or do we rework it. Then actually show up to it.

Run It As a 30-Day Trial

One of you might read all of this and feel completely on board, and the other might feel like it's a lot of effort for something that should just happen naturally. If that's where you are, don't argue about whether the idea is right. Propose an experiment instead.

For 30 days, each of you puts your full attention on the other person's safety, security, love, respect, and acceptance rather than your own. Your own needs still matter. You're testing something specific: whether you actually end up more met this way than you do when everyone privately manages their own needs and criticizes or withdraws the moment those needs go unmet. Most people already know which version of a relationship that second one describes. Many are already living in it.

Put an end date on it. At the end, ask honestly, not did this feel nice, but did I end up with more of what I actually needed. Let the results make the argument, not the theory.

DO THIS

Pick a start date this week. Write "30 DAYS" on a shared calendar with a real end date, not an open-ended promise. Revisit this guide together when it arrives.

Ready to go deeper than a four-step practice?

These four steps are a real doorway, and they work. What I watch happen in my practice is bigger than a worksheet: two people learning to hold each other's nervous system like something precious, in real time, with someone steady in the room. That's what Couples Work is for: a held container for building your own bubble, with guidance instead of guesswork.

Not in a partnership right now, and this still stirred something in you? The same body that needs a witnessed practice with a partner needs one with itself first. My Temple work, Sacred Feminine retreats, and one-to-one mentorship exist for exactly that season.

[Explore Couples Work](#)

A NOTE FROM SANDI



I'm Sandi, founder of Medicine Within, based in Amsterdam. My root training is in embodied tantra, temple facilitation, and Kambô, always led by the nervous system, because none of the rest holds if the body isn't safe first. Couples and relationship work is where I'm currently deepening my own training, and this guide comes directly out of that: the practice I use, still growing as I teach it.